+113%

Jaipur's glow has more than doubled since 2013.

Like-for-like **January–August** night-light radiance over the Jaipur Development Authority's Master Development Plan area — the same eight months every year, so this year is measured on the same footing as the last. The radiance this measures has gone from **3.50** to **7.44** nW·cm^{-2}·sr^{-1}.

+68% on the annual record

9.5%/yr since 2021

0.55 → 0.86 of the MDP lit

Source: VIIRS Day/Night Band (NASA/NOAA) night-time lights, Earth Observation Group, Payne Institute for Public Policy, Colorado School of Mines (Elvidge et al.). Statistic = normalised Sum of Lights (nW·cm^{-2}·sr^{-1}); lit area counts pixels at or above the 1.6 threshold. 2026 is January–August, compared like-for-like.

Where the light comes from

Official satellite night-light data, clipped to the Jaipur Development Authority's Master Development Plan 2025 boundary. Nothing here is modelled or estimated.

The instrument

The **VIIRS Day/Night Band** (NASA/NOAA Suomi-NPP) — the sensor that images the earth's low light. Annual composites for 2013–2025 and monthly composites for 2026, from the Earth Observation Group at the Colorado School of Mines.

The statistic

The **normalised Sum of Lights**: total radiance divided by area, in **nW·cm⁻²·sr⁻¹**. It is a mean, so a bigger area cannot inflate it — the MDP's **17** planning zones are directly comparable.

The threshold

A pixel counts as lit at or above **1.6 nW·cm⁻²·sr⁻¹**. That is the background-noise threshold used in India's own night-lights atlas, not a number chosen to flatter the result.

Why 2013, and why August

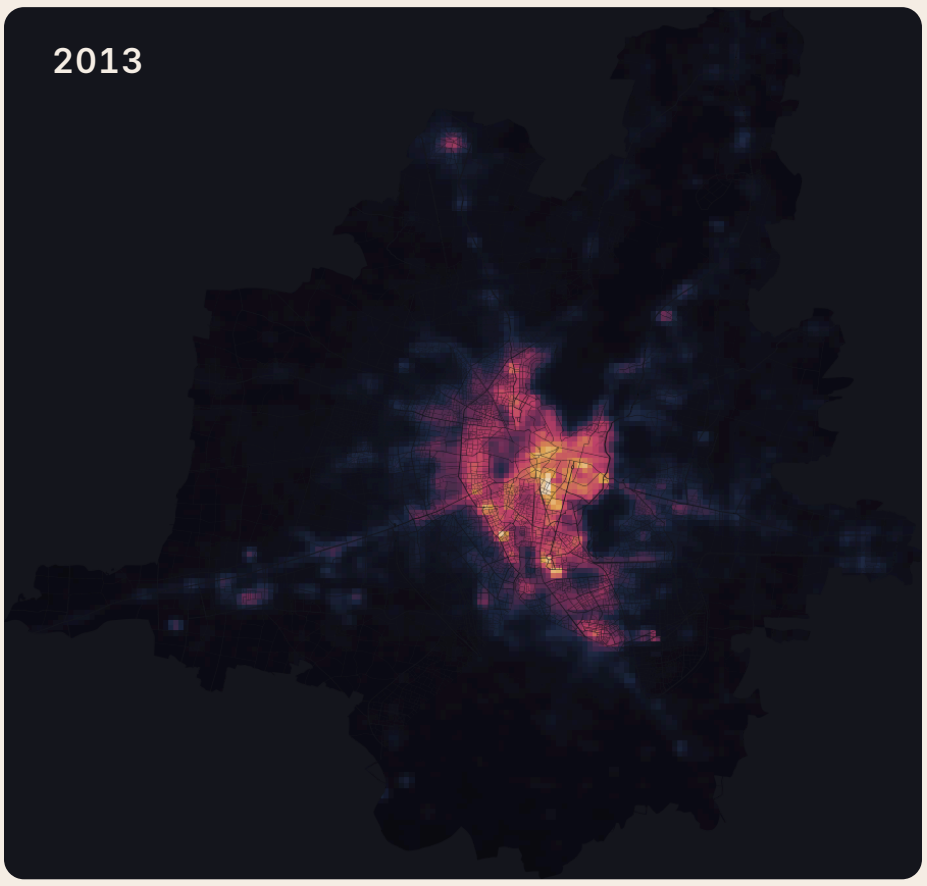
The satellite record for this area begins in **2013**, so the series runs **13** years. The annual composite cannot exist for an unfinished year, so **2026** is a like-for-like **January–August** mean: the same eight months, every year.

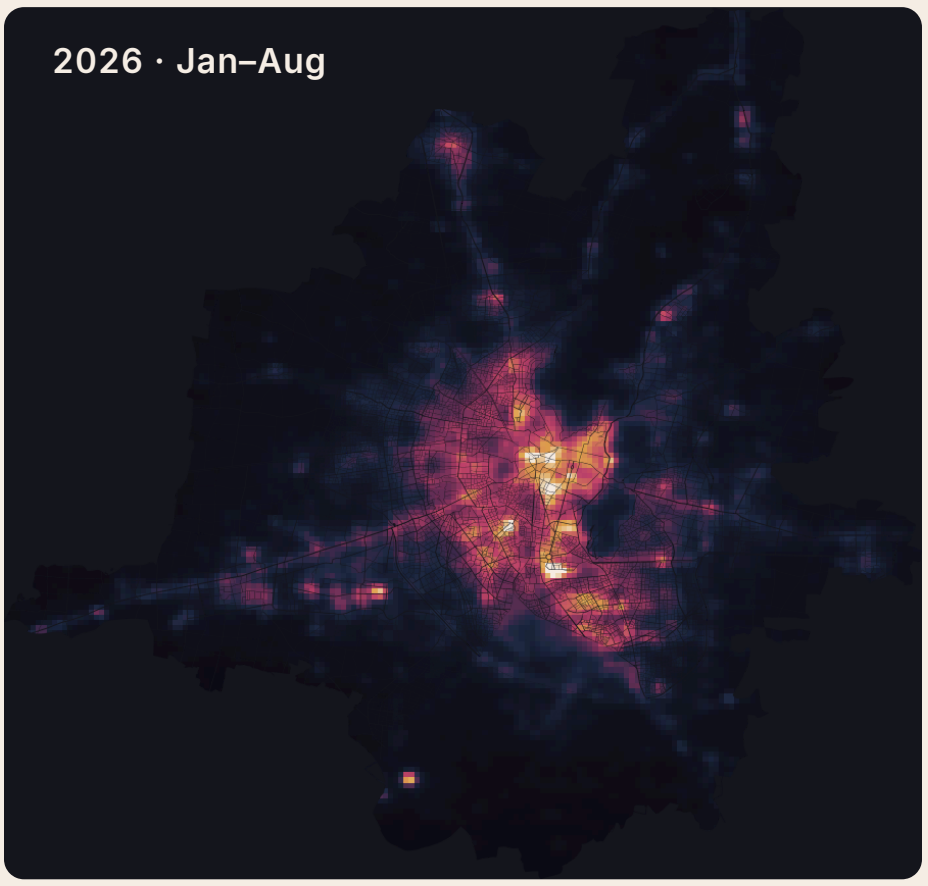
READ THIS BEFORE THE NUMBERS

Jaipur is already **one of the brightest cities in India**. A bright city grows its *relative* radiance more slowly than a dark one, so the percentages below are structurally modest compared with a newly lit district. India's own night-lights atlas names Rajasthan's most-prominent change districts as **Sikar, Bharatpur, Karauli and Jhunjhunu** — **not** Jaipur. That is a statement about how much headroom each place had, not about how much Jaipur built.

Every figure in this deck was recomputed from the underlying per-zone, per-year values before use: **27 of 27** headline figures reproduced exactly, with none in disagreement.

The same boundary, thirteen years apart





Identical outline, identical colour scale, identical eight-month window — only the year differs. In **2013** the light sat in a compact core; by **2026** it has spread along the corridors and into the ring towns, and the dark interior has filled in.

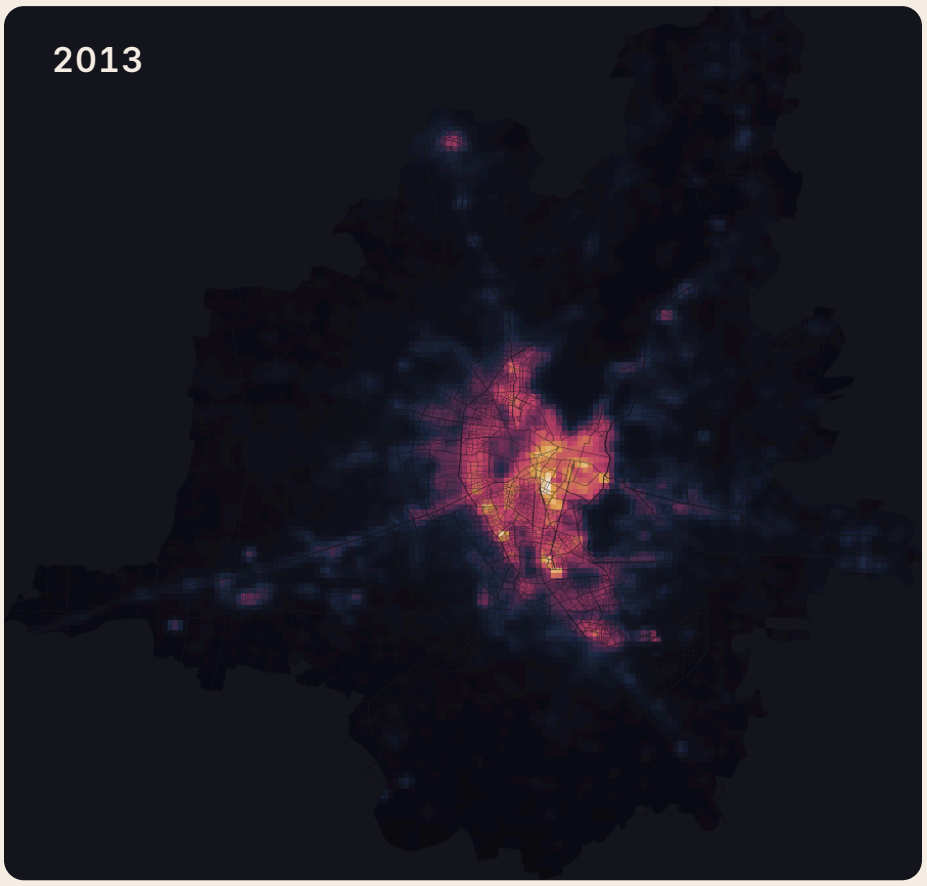
3.50 → 7.44
Jan–Aug mean radiance, 2013 vs 2026

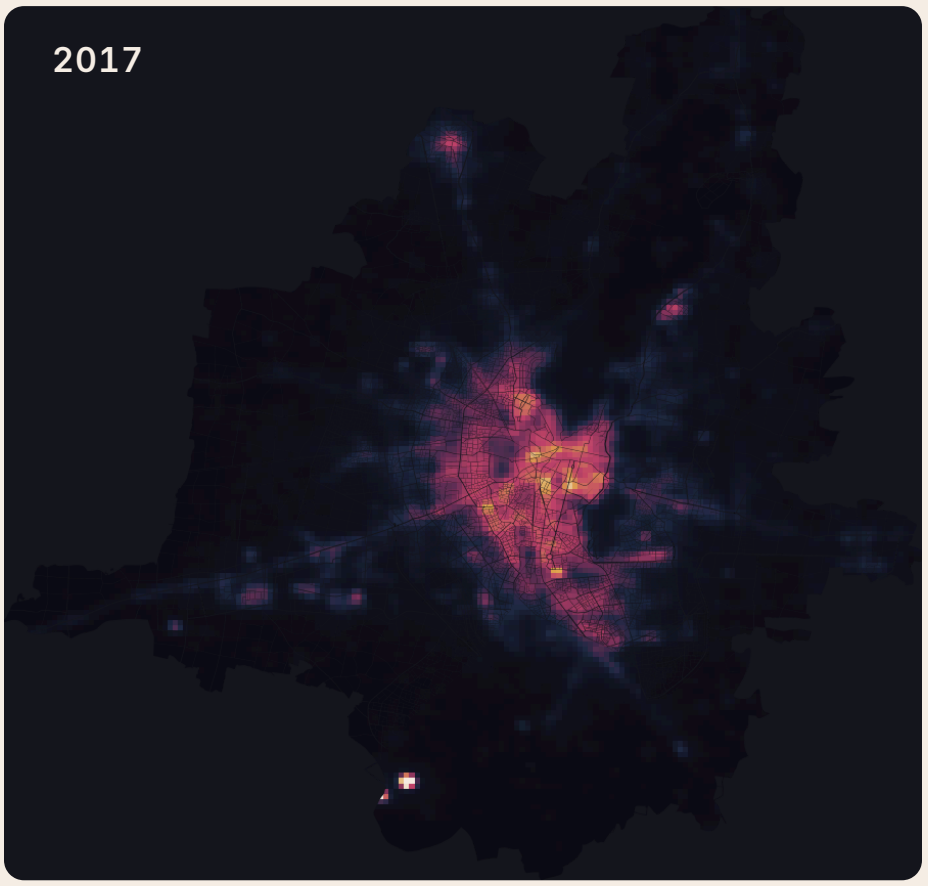
+113%
Change across the two frames, like-for-like

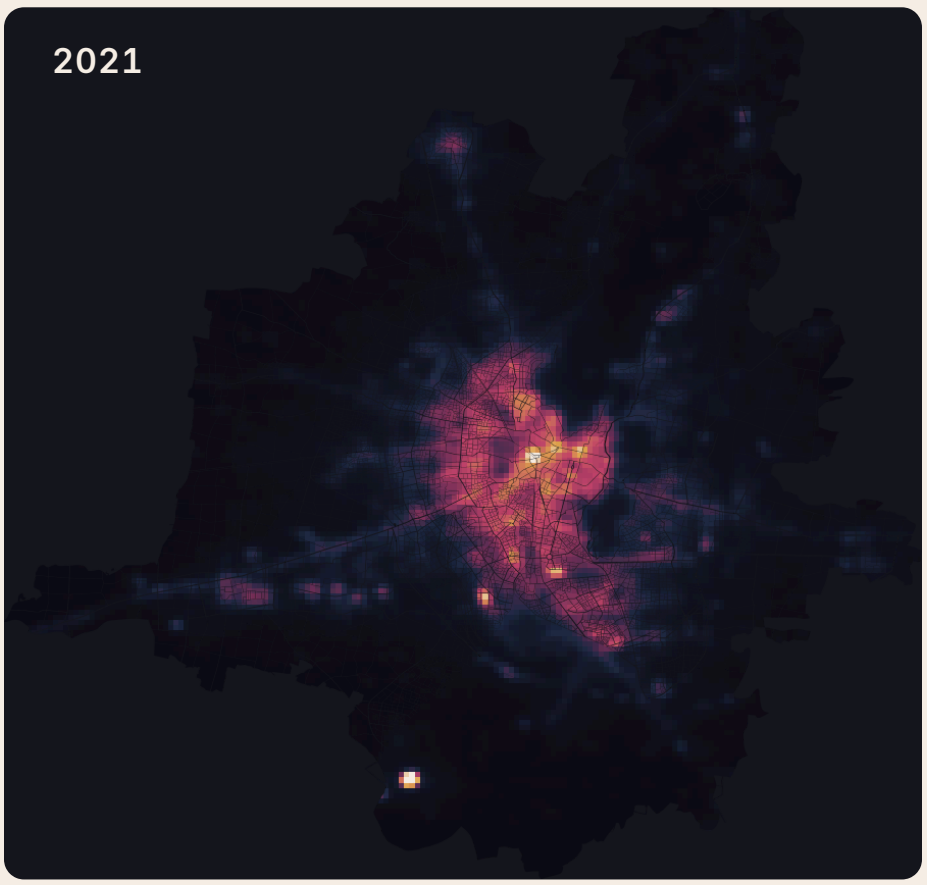
0.55 → 0.86
Share of MDP land above the lit threshold

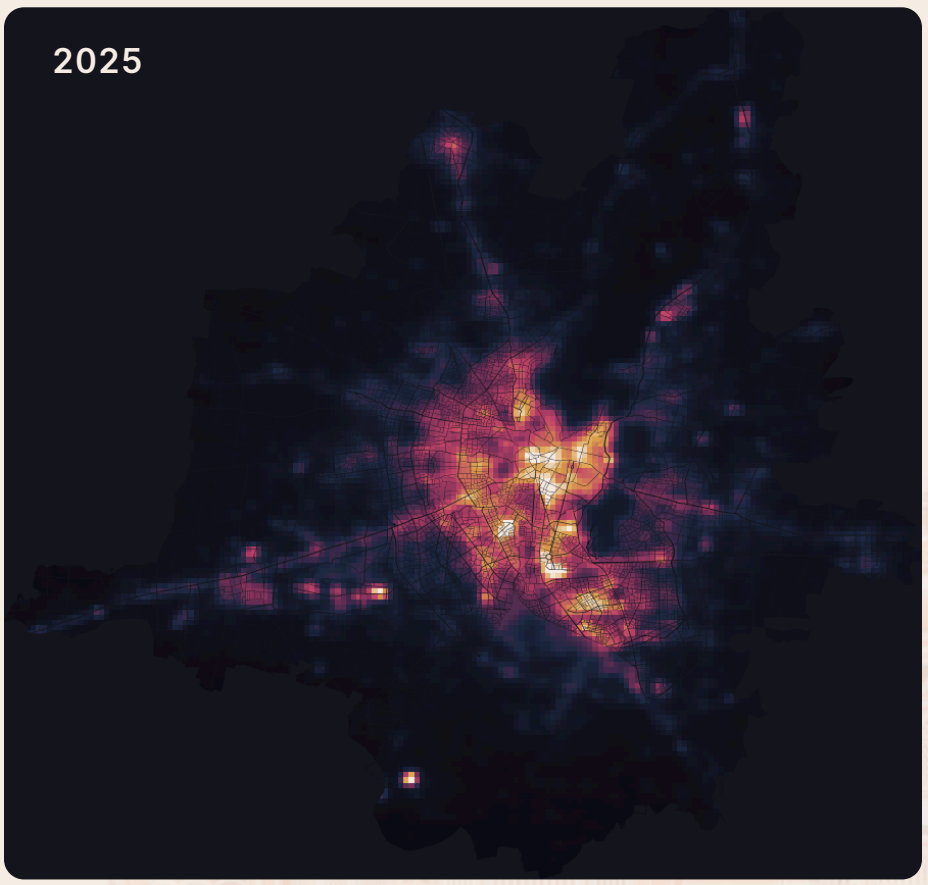
The light stopped being a single core. By 2026 the glow sits on **separate nodes** — the corridors out of the city and the ring settlements each carry their own, which is why the whole map now reads as a network rather than a centre with a halo.

Watching it spread





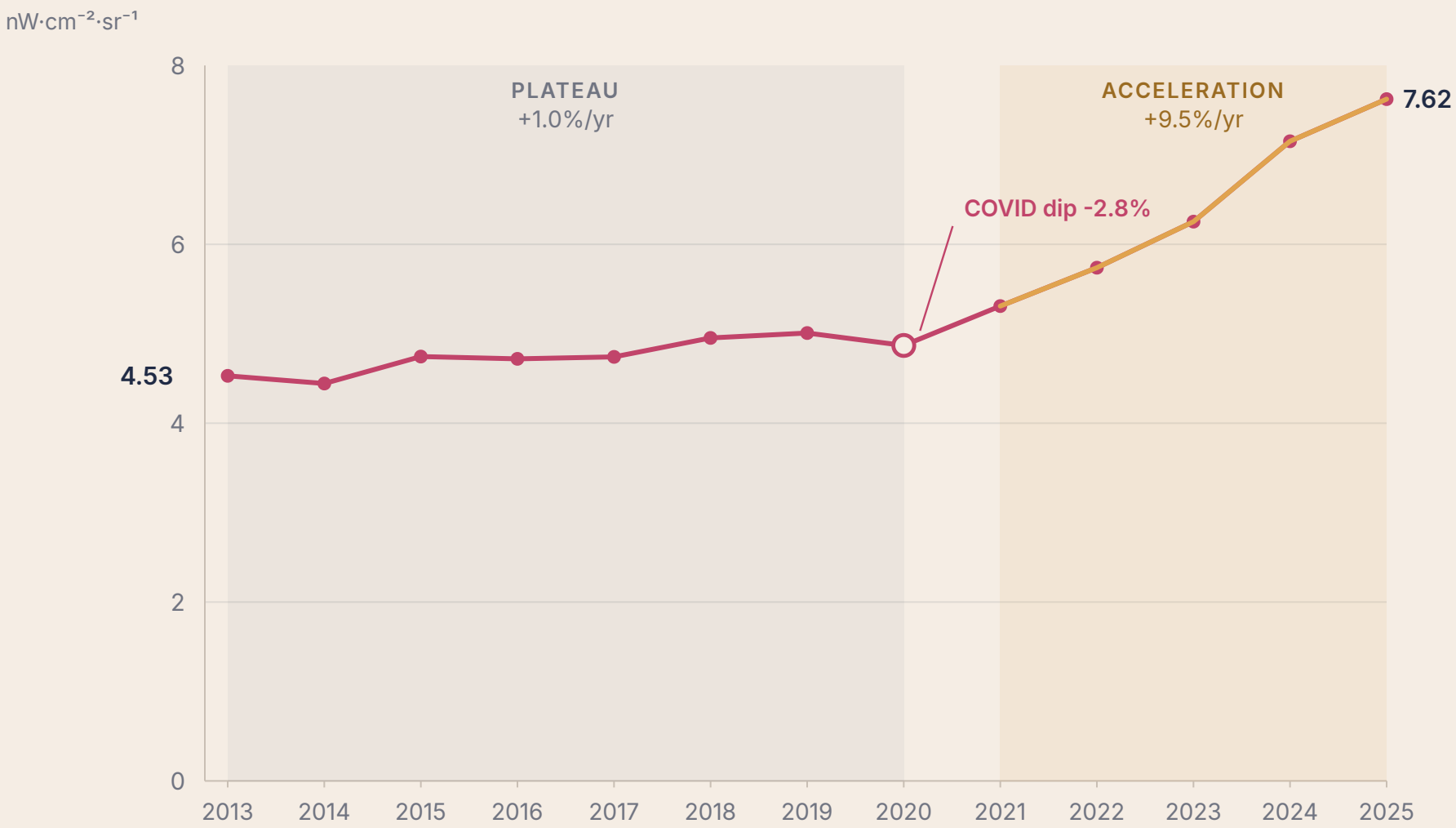




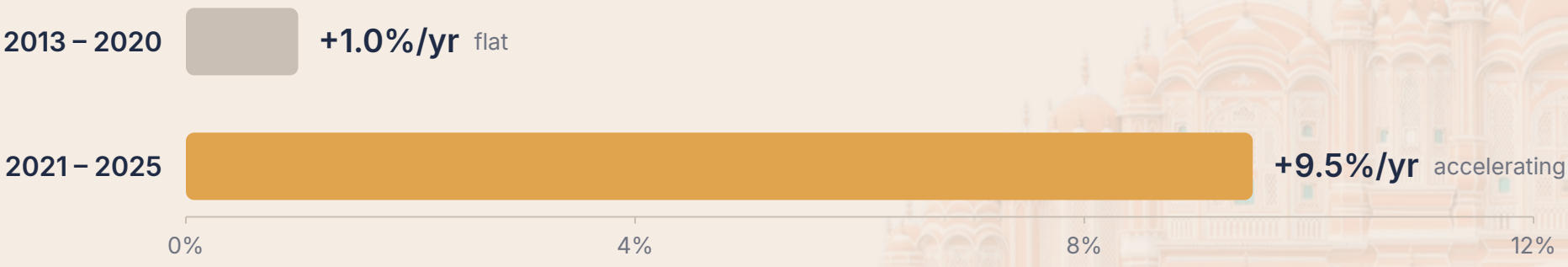
Annual composites, same scale throughout. The change is not uniform: the north and the southern lobe brighten well before the eastern arm does.

Flat for seven years, then not

MDP-wide mean radiance barely moved to 2020 — then it broke upward. The break is the finding: **1.0% a year** across 2013–2020, against **9.5% a year** across 2021–2025.



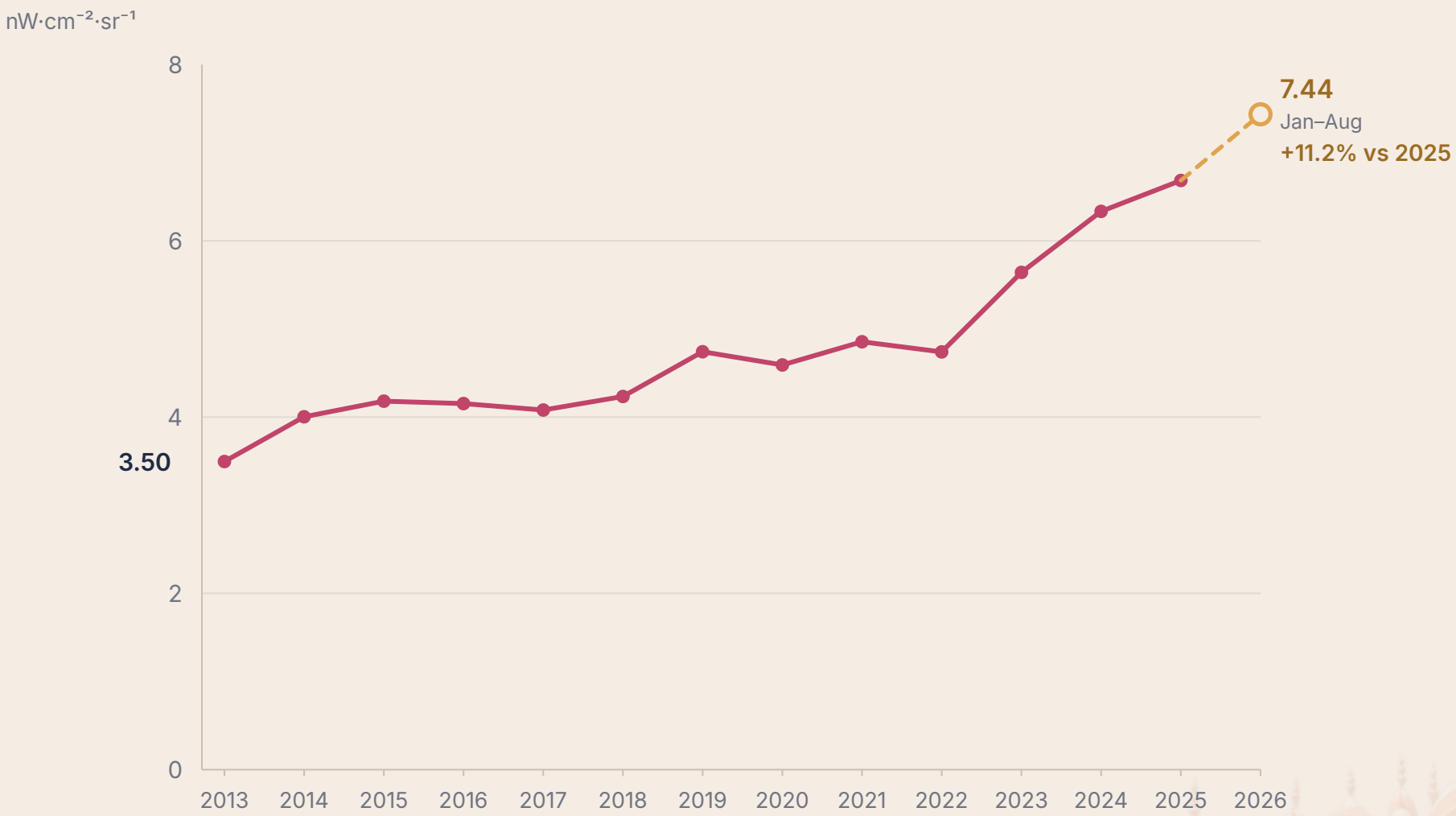
MDP-wide mean radiance, annual VIIRS composite. Zero-based axis. The 2021-on acceleration is the story; the flat 2013-2020 stretch is not.



Compound annual growth rate of the same measure over two stretches. Same data, same method — only the era differs.

The current year, on equal footing

An unfinished year cannot be compared with finished ones, so every point here is the same **January–August** window. On that basis 2026 is up **+11.2%** on 2025 — a steeper step than any year since 2021.



Like-for-like January–August mean radiance, the same eight months each year. 2026 is eight months, not a year — drawn hollow for that reason.

3.50 → 7.44

Jan–Aug mean radiance, 2013 vs 2026

+113%

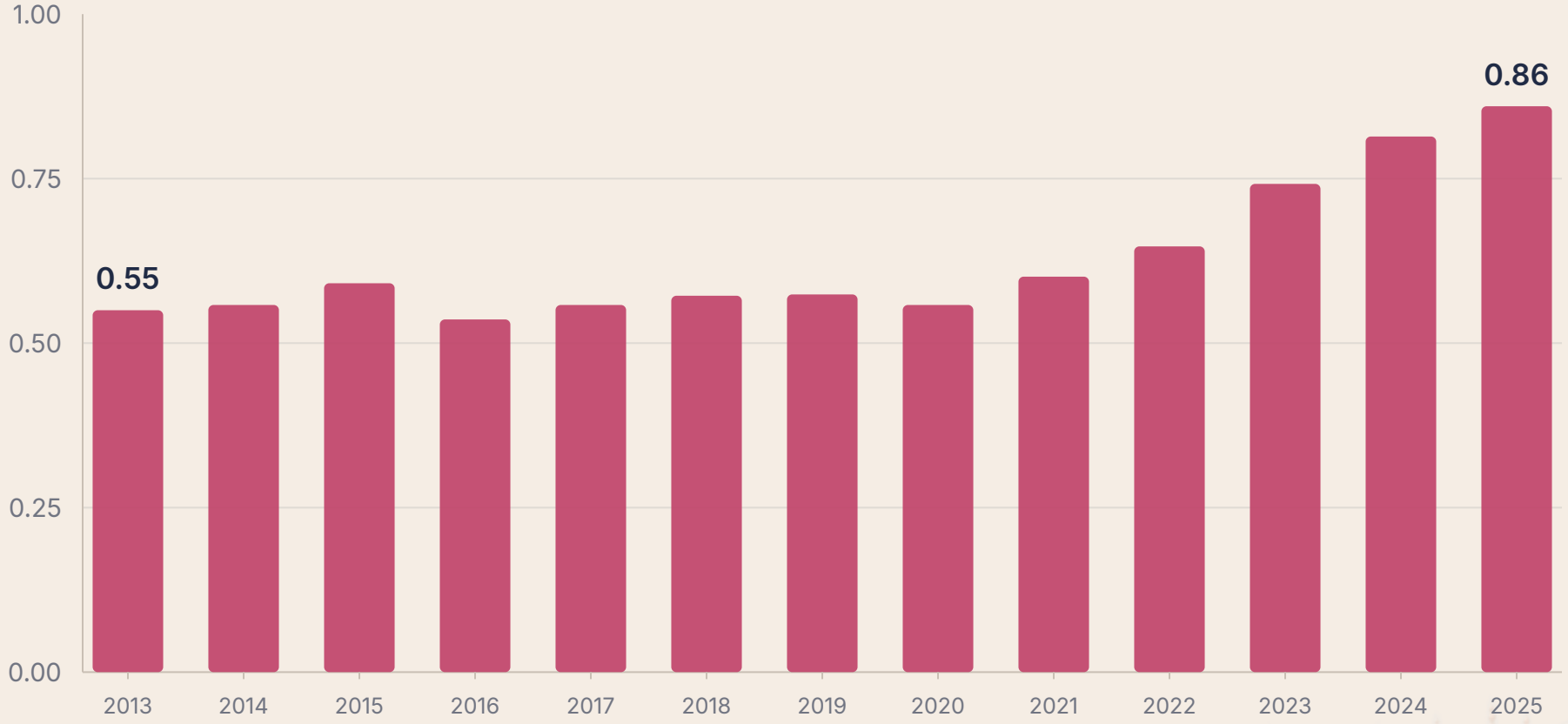
Change over the period, like-for-like

8.9%/yr

Pace since 2021 on the same window

More of the map is lit, not just brighter

Brighter pixels and more of them are two different stories. The share of MDP land at or above the threshold has gone from **0.55** to **0.86** — from about half the plan area to about **six-sevenths** of it.



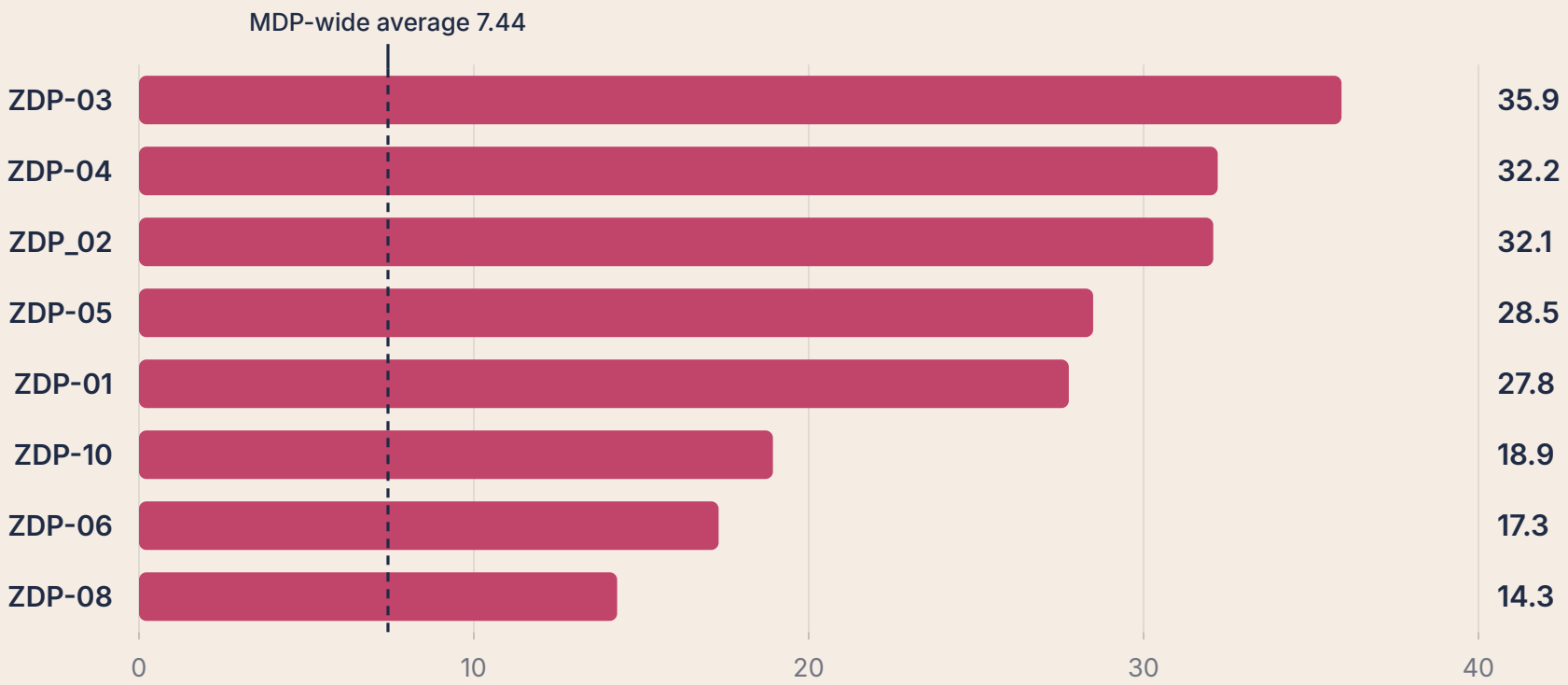
Share of MDP area at or above 1.6 nW·cm⁻²·sr⁻¹, the background-noise threshold. A share, so it cannot be inflated by the MDP's own size.

WHAT THAT MEANS ON THE GROUND

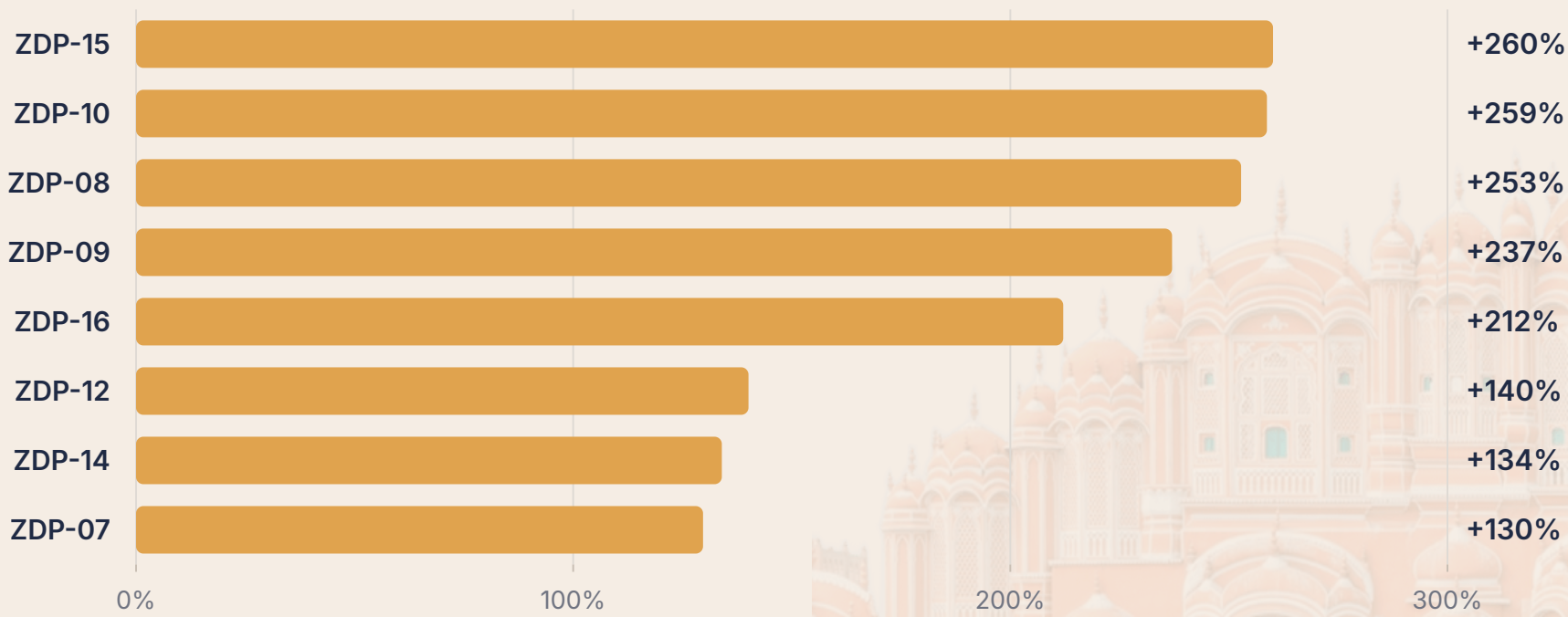
The **5** brightest zones were **already fully lit in 2013**, so every gain in lit area had to come from somewhere else. The least-lit zone went from **0.04** to **0.59**, and all **17** planning zones now sit above half lit — **12** did in 2013.

The bright zones and the fast zones are not the same zones

Zones already bright in 2026 grew the least; the fastest growers are the dimmer ones. Across the **17** planning zones, that relationship holds almost everywhere — of the **8** brightest zones, only **2** also rank among the **8** fastest-growing.



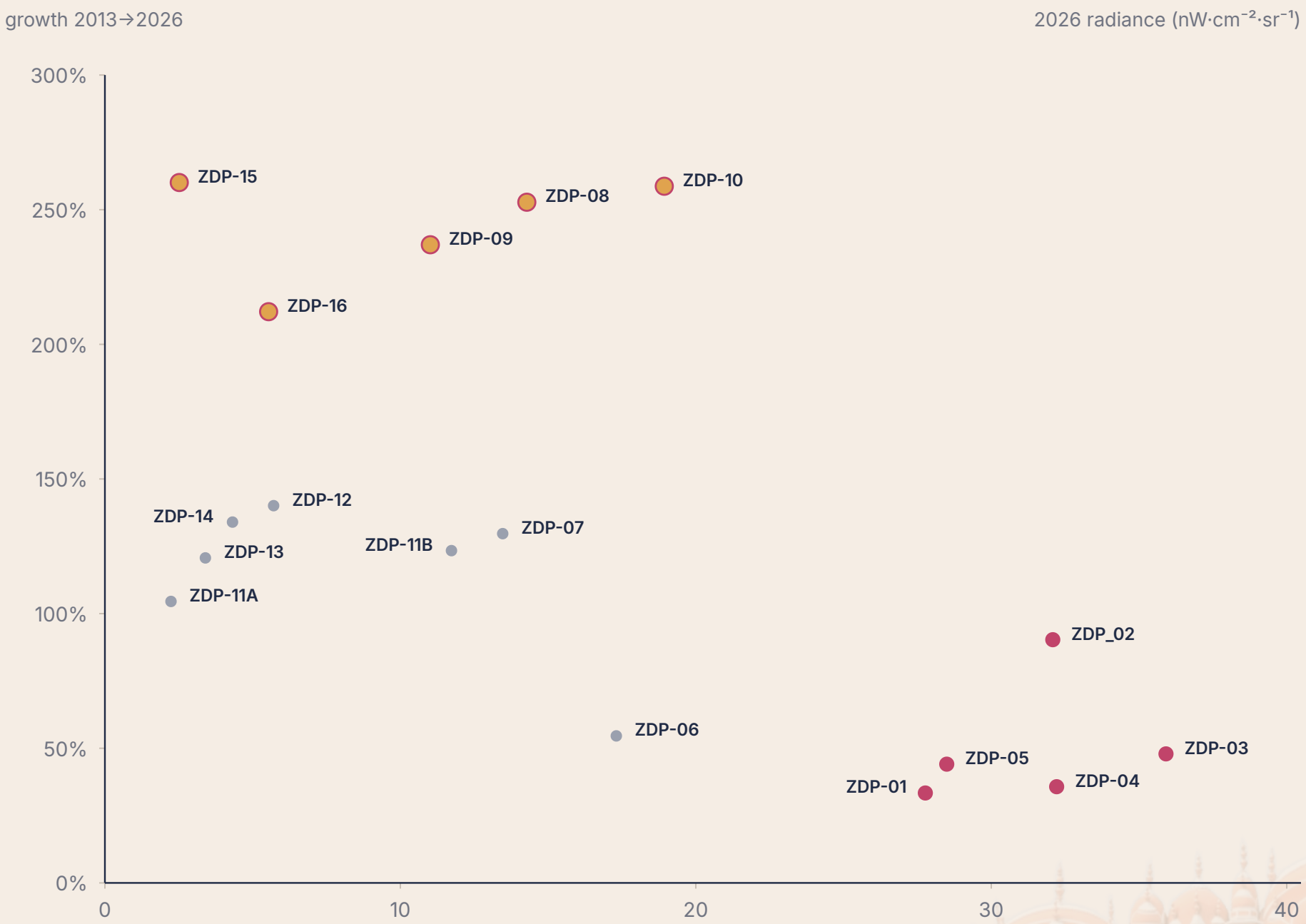
Mean radiance (nW·cm^{-2}·sr^{-1}) by planning zone, January–August 2026, against the MDP-wide average. Zone names are the official MDP planning-zone labels.



Growth in January–August mean radiance (nW·cm^{-2}·sr^{-1}), 2013 to 2026. Same window, same method; only the zone differs.

Jaipur is the bright one already

That is the whole reason its percentage growth looks unremarkable. The brightest zone carries about **16 times** the radiance of the dimmest — there is simply less dark left to light up.



Every dot is one planning zone, and every dot is named. Rose marks the five brightest zones of 2026, gold the five fastest-growing. Zones already bright sit on the right and grew least.

TWO THINGS THIS DECK IS NOT CLAIMING

One. That Jaipur grew faster than other districts — by this measure it did not, and India's own night-lights atlas points to **Sikar, Bharatpur, Karauli and Jhunjhunu** as Rajasthan's fastest-changing districts. **Two.** That radiance equals economic activity. It is a proxy: it tracks lighting, construction and population, and it saturates — the brightest cores understate themselves.

1

Since 2021 the city has been lighting up far faster than it was before

On the annual record the pace went from **1.0%** a year across 2013–2020 to **9.5%** a year across 2021–2025. Like-for-like, **2026** is up **+11.2%** on 2025.

2

The growth has moved to the edges

The share of MDP land above the lit threshold rose from **0.55** to **0.86**, and the fastest-growing zones are the dimmer ones — **ZDP-15** at **+260%** over the period, against about **48%** in the brightest zone.

3

Read it as a floor, not a ranking

Jaipur is already saturated and bright, so its relative growth is the wrong yardstick for how much it built. The honest comparison is against its own past — and against that, it has more than doubled, on both the annual record and the like-for-like window.

4

The next chapter is already visible on the periphery

The fastest-growing zones are still the dimmer ones — **ZDP-15**, **ZDP-10** and **ZDP-08** each more than doubled over the period, while the brightest zone managed **under a fifth** of that (18% against 260%). Watch the edge, not the core.

Source: VIIRS Day/Night Band (NASA/NOAA) night-time lights, Earth Observation Group, Payne Institute for Public Policy, Colorado School of Mines (Elvidge et al.). Statistic = normalised Sum of Lights (nW·cm^{-2}·sr^{-1}); lit area counts pixels at or above the 1.6 threshold. 2026 is January–August, compared like-for-like.